

DID INDIA TOPPLE HIM?

The ousted premier of a tiny West African nation accuses the Indian ambassador of scheming to overthrow his government

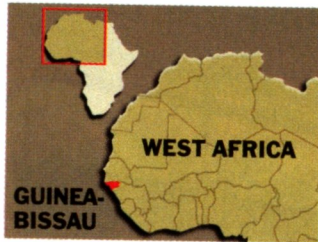
■ By Saurabh Shukla

Guinea Bissau may be a small blip on India's diplomatic radar, but for now it has the potential to damage India's unblemished record of ethical diplomacy, of doing business with foreign regimes, and not destabilising them.

Amidst diplomatic bustle and political diatribe over the Indo-US nuclear deal, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh received a shocker. Aristide Gomes, former prime minister of a West African country, Guinea Bissau, has written to him accusing the Indian ambassador to that country, Parbati Sen Vyas, of having had a role in toppling his government for commercial consideration at the behest of an Indian firm.

Guinea Bissau is roughly the size of Taiwan on the North Atlantic coast of West Africa. The former Portuguese colony has been plagued with political instability and was recently in the news for cocaine smuggling and illegal immigrations to Europe. Now, the latest diplomatic tangle has shifted the spotlight to a different issue.

The Prime Minister's Office has sought comments from the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), and the Foreign Office has asked Vyas for an explanation. "I felt it my bounden duty to confidentially inform you the role played by the Indian diplomats, possibly in making and unmaking political stability in the region in which my country was just born and developing, not on the ground of promoting your nation's interest, but on venal ground,"



Gomes writes.

INDIA TODAY has obtained a copy of the letter, which makes some damaging allegations against Vyas, an officer of the 1975 batch of the Indian Foreign Service. "I have strong reason to believe that Her Excellency posted in Dakar, Senegal, who also happens to look after the affairs of my country, has a hand in dirty politics, which I am sure would not have the Indian Government's authorisation. She has been urging me to freshly award the \$25 million contract for the Indian line of credit to one Mohan Energy Corporation Private Limited, who offered me a huge amount for cancelling the contract already awarded to another entrepreneur," writes Gomes.

He further states that he is privy to the disquieting role of the businesspersons, recommended by Vyas, in manipulating political structures and situations to gain commercial advantages at the cost of political peace and tranquility of the country. While MEA is tightlipped on the entire matter, Vyas denies the charges, "The allegations are baseless. I did not lobby for any company with Mr Gomes. On the contrary, he had asked me to expedite the line of credit. We have no role in destabilising his government, but the situation here is such that there is a lot of political instability in Guinea Bissau," Vyas told INDIA TODAY from Senegal.

Sources in the Foreign Office say the Government of India would never authorise the Indian envoy or the Indian Embassy to support any political player in Guinea Bissau. "It does

“I have strong reason to believe that the Indian ambassador has a hand in dirty politics and has been urging me to award a contract to a company.”

ARISTIDE GOMES, FORMER PRIME MINISTER, GUINEA BISSAU



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